

As a part of the Seafood Export Facilitator (SEF) service we have been talking with industry to find out what you would like additional information on. To make the export process easier to understand our SEFs have been busy recording a range of short videos to help both current and new exporters.

Do you know exactly what you are looking for?

Scroll through the list below to see if we have a video on the topic – if we don't, [send us a quick email](#) to let us know! Then have a look at our [Exporting Fish and Fish Products from Australia](#) page.

Are you new to the seafood game and don't know where to start?

We suggest watching all of the videos from top to bottom, we will keep them in a logical order so that they build on one another. Then have a look at our [Exporting Fish and Fish Products from Australia](#) page.

Importantly, we need your feedback to ensure that the videos are helpful and cover the right topics. [Send us an email](#) and let us know how we can improve them in the future!

So, you want to export seafood?

Need to know the basics? This is a good place to start. Our SEFs cover everything from the difference between an exporter and a processor, through to when you need an export permit.

Video uploaded: 17 January 2023

Requirements for being an exporter of seafood are going to be different, depending on whether you're buying and on selling product or manufacturing it yourself and then exporting it.

If you're buying and on selling, you'll require an exporter number so that your company's name appears on the documentation that will accompany the product and identify you as the owner.

You can easily get an export number from the department by completing and submitting a form on our website.

This is the number you'll need to provide to a freight forwarder so they can prepare your export documentation.

You'll also need to provide your freight forwarder with a declaration of compliance from the manufacturer of the goods you're exporting.

This is because the products you want to on sell must be sourced from an export registered establishment.

There's a list of export registered establishments available on the department's website.

This list includes establishments that can store already manufactured goods for export, making sure they remain in the export chain.

If you want to process or store goods for export, this needs to occur in an export registered establishment.

You'll need to apply to the department for this export registration, which can also be done on the department's website, but the requirements are quite different.

You'll need a physical premise that can be registered and a documented system that describes to the department how you prepare or store your goods in such a way

that they will meet the requirements of export legislation. We call this documented system an approved arrangement.

Making sure premises ready for inspection and you have the required documentation is going to take more time than applying for an exporter number and fees and charges will apply.

If you decide you want to manufacture for export. There are some first steps, and this includes determining if your product does in fact need to be prepared in an export registered establishment with an approved arrangement.

For more information on which products need to be prepared in a registered establishment and more information on importing country requirements, check out our video on the difference between prescribed and not prescribed goods.

You can have a look at our step by step guide for exporting fish and fish products on the department's website.

You can speak with your customer or importer, AusTrade or a seafood industry body.

As the seafood export facilitator, I'm able to help you with this.

Just send me an email and I'll point you in the right direction.

When is a fish a fish?

In this video, our SEF talks you through the differences between prescribed fish products and not prescribed fish products. Based on this, the video also touches on which products need to be manufactured in an export registered establishment.

Video uploaded: 17 January 2023

Hi, my name is Lisa, and I'm one of the seafood export facilitators at the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

In this short video, I'm going to tell you when your product needs to be prepared in an export registered establishment.

Whether your product needs to be prepared in an export registered establishment can depend on a number of factors is the product you're preparing a fish product where you're intending to send it?

How much of it is there?

What's it going to be used for?

When is it going to be used?

Of course, what I'm talking about here is the difference between a prescribed good and a non prescribed good, so what's a prescribed good.

The reason for all these different factors is because not all products that are exported from Australia are regulated.

The government determines when regulation is required to maintain trade with other countries.

Regulation ensures that only products that meet the requirements are exported.

Regulation is typically applied to products that can impact human and animal health, and where importing Countries require assurances that the goods are safe.

When certain goods are regulated, we call them prescribed goods.

So, when a fish are fish products prescribed the fish and fish products that are prescribed under the Export Control Act are products for the purpose of food for humans.

Next thing to consider is how much fish is in the food. For fish products to be prescribed, the product must contain more than 50 percent fish by weight.

This means a product such as a fish stock that contains 5% fish by weight, with other ingredients being water and vegetables etcetera wouldn't be considered to be a prescribed Good.

One thing to remember here is that there are rules around what Australia considers to be prescribed. Other countries may consider that a product containing 10% fish is a fish and fish product.

If this is the case, and the importing country requires assurances, the department can certify that product provided it meets the same standards as other prescribed goods.

This includes being manufactured in an export registered establishment.

It's also important to consider quantities of products in the same way that is fish for human consumption that's prescribed doesn't require export certification if it's taken out of Australia and small quantities.

For example, less than 10 kg of fish under 10 litres of fish stock or two kg of dried fish is able to be taken out of Australia as samples, small consignments or for personal use, not including dried abalone, where any quantity requires an export permit.

However, this is an Australian requirement and again the importing country may require certification for any amount.

There are also some circumstances where certification isn't required. These include when the fish has been sent overseas to an Australian territory such as Christmas Island, or when the fish is served as a meal on an aeroplane or a ship leaving Australia.

So, generally speaking, if you're preparing a fish product as human food, you will need to be manufactured and stored in an export registered establishment.

You also need to consider if you're preparing fish product that are not prescribed under Australia's rules, you may also need to prepare it and export registered establishment to meet importing country requirements.

To find out more about this, you can go online and check out our manual of importing country requirements. We call it MICOR.

It will help you determine whether there are importing country requirements that you need to be aware of, which may impact whether your product is prescribed or not,

It's important to speak to your importer about what certification is required by their government agencies.

You can also check the overseas government web sites or you can speak to our department.

The examples I just provided you are not comprehensive. For all of the Australian government requirements, you can look at our step by step guide for exporting fish and fish products on the department's website.

So, if you're sourcing products to export, this should help you understand if you need to source them from an export registered establishment or if you manufacture fish products if you need to register your premises.

For more information, check out our other videos such as so you want to export seafood.

Exporting your product for a seafood tradeshow or expo

If you are looking to export your products overseas to participate in a seafood tradeshow or expo then there are a few things you need to consider before doing so. You also need to make sure that you allow enough time to go through the process! Click below to hear one of our SEFs tell you everything you need to know.

Video uploaded: 17 January 2023

Hi, my name is Lisa, and I'm one of the Seafood Export Facilitators at the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

In this video, I'm going to tell you about the requirements you may need to consider if you're intending to supply seafood products to an overseas trade show or expo.

This will also apply if you're considering sending a sample shipment to a new customer or to a new destination.

Question appeared in the video: I want to send some seafood samples to an international seafood expo, what do I need to know?

Well, first of all, are you the exporter or are you the manufacturer of the product or are you both?

What I mean by this is the exporter is the person arranging to send the sample, not necessarily the person who will be producing the product.

This matters because whether or not you can get the product into a particular country comes down to how the product was sourced and how it is prepared for export by the manufacturer.

Question appeared in the video: I'm an exporter, what do I need to know about the product I am intending to send over for the expo?

The first thing you need to consider is that some seafood products, regardless of where they are being exported to, will require an export permit to leave Australia.

Question appeared in the video: What needs an export permit, and what doesn't?

Generally speaking, all fish and fish products that are intended for human consumption as food in the importing country will require an export permit.

These are the kinds of products we would call prescribed fish products. So, obviously this doesn't include fish products that are intended to be fed to livestock or pets.

Fish products which are not prescribed, which means they do not need an export permit, include fish products that contain less than 50% fish by weight.

For example, a fish stock or an encapsulated fish product such as a fish oil capsule you would take for health reasons rather than eating as a meal.

All fish product that is going to be eaten as food are going to need an export permit to leave Australia.

Question appeared in the video: How do I get an export permit for my product?

Well, you need to make sure that the product you intend to send is eligible for an export permit.

The department can only issue export permits for fish products when they have been prepared in an export registered establishment and have remained in the export chain until they are exported.

Question appeared in the video: I didn't manufacture these products, how do I know what they were manufactured in an export registered establishment?

This is information that you'll need to get from the manufacturer who will also need to provide you with the declaration that that product meets Australia's export requirements.

This is in the form of a declaration that you will need to have to make an application for an export permit.

Question appeared in the video: I only have a small amount of product, do I still need an export permit?

Small amounts of prescribed fish products can be taken out of Australia without an export permit if they are less than 10 kg of fish, 10 litres of liquid fish or two kg of dried fish unless it's dried abalone, in which case any amount requires an export permit.

In fact, these small amounts are not even required to be prepared in an export registered establishment.

What you do need to remember is that an export permit is about getting permission for the product to leave Australia.

Some countries require a government certificate for any quantity of fish to enter their country, and this may include fish products that Australia would consider as not prescribed.

Question appeared in the video: How do I find out if I need a government certificate, and if I do need one how do I get it?

The country hosting the trade show or where you are sending your samples may be willing to accept small quantities of fish products as trade samples without a government certificate.

However, requirements for an export permit to leave Australia will not change if a government certificate is required. This will be issued by the department. After you applied for and been issued an export permit, you can check our manual of importing country requirements, we call it MICOR on the Department's website for any specific importing country requirements.

This could include things like where a consignment needs to be accompanied by additional government documentation, or whether or not the importing country will accept all species of fish or just some species of fish.

Question appeared in the video: Is it difficult to export to countries with additional requirements if this is the first time I will have done so.

This depends on what the additional requirements are. These requirements can vary from the manufacturing establishment having to be country listed prior to preparing the product through to simply checking in MICOR to determine which government certificate is required to accompany the product.

Because importing country requirements vary, you need to be aware of the details when planning to attend a trade show, because there may be activities that you need to undertake additional

documentation you need to prepare or information that you need to confirm to ensure your sample meets the requirements for export from Australia and importing country requirements into the destination country.

Some of these activities, such as adding a country listing to an existing registered establishment, can take some time. You must factor this in, or you will not get the required documentation in time to get your product or samples to the trade show.

Now, I know this is a lot of information to take in so a few key points to take away are an export permit may be required for your sample to leave Australia. The importing country may have additional requirements that you need to meet.

A good place to start is with your customer or if you're attending a trade show, you can speak to the organisers about arrangements for shipping your sample of product.

Then it's always a good idea to check MICOR and find out if there are any other specific requirements.

You need to be aware of some of the other resources you have available to you.

Our Seafood Industry Australia, Austrade and, of course, the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

As the Seafood Export Facilitator, I'm able to help you with this. Just send me an email and I'll point you in the right direction.

Finally, you need to make sure that you allow yourself plenty of time to go through this process as it can take some time.

I just want to be an exporter (not a processor!)

In our video 'So you want to export seafood?' we talk about the difference between being an exporter and a processor. If you aren't sure what the difference is watch that video first, and then once you have decided that you want to be an exporter (not a processor!), then this is the video for you.

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi! My name is Amy and I am one of the department's Seafood Export Facilitators!

In our video 'So you want to export seafood?' we talk about the difference between an exporter and a processor. If you have decided that you want to be an exporter (not a processor!), then keep watching! If you want to be a processor and the exporter of the product you make – check out our video “I want to be a processor AND the exporter of the fish products I make!” instead!

If you only want to be an exporter you need to complete this form to get an exporter number. If you already have an exporter number for other products, such as meat and dairy, you will still need to submit this form to add fish to your existing number.

All export documentation for fish is electronically managed through the departments Electronic Export Documentation System – we call it EXDOC. EXDOC links with Australia’s customs system, and allows you to generate an export permit for your product. An export permit is required for the product to LEAVE Australia. For some countries you will also need a Health Certificate for the product to ENTER that country. If a health certificate is required, EXDOC will automatically issue this with your export permit.

To access EXDOC yourself you would need to purchase software for your computer – but you can also work with a freight forwarder or agent that already has access to the EXDOC system to do this for you (smaller or infrequent exporters do this all the time).

This is where you need your exporter number, whoever is entering the information into EXDOC will need this number to identify you as the exporter on the export documentation.

The EXDOC user will also have to make a declaration in the system on your behalf. They may request copies of documentation as proof. This is a declaration that all of the information you are providing about the product to be exported is true and correct. There are penalties for making false declarations.

This declaration also states that you – the exporter – have a copy of a Declaration of Compliance signed by someone at the last registered establishment that prepared the goods for export. This is sometimes referred to as a ‘manufacturers declaration’.

This declaration must be a document received from the processing establishment. It can also be the declaration made on transfer documentation (we call this a transfer certificate), from the processing establishment to a registered cold store that is storing or loading the product before export.

If the product details entered into EXDOC are not correct – it will not issue an export permit or a Health Certificate if one is required. So always double check the product information you provide to the EXDOC user is correct.

Details of what must be entered into EXDOC include:

Consignee details (this means who you are sending it to)

Shipping details (this refers to how you are getting your product to its destination)

The export registration number of the establishment that processed the product

Dates of when the product was processed

A correct description of the product by fish name and species

Accurate details of the gross and net weight of the product

And for shellfish like oysters – the date harvested, and the harvest area

It is your responsibility as the exporter to ensure that all of the details entered into EXDOC are correct – incorrect information (for example under estimation of product weights) can result in penalties,

detained consignments, or a requirement to return the goods to Australia. Save yourself the hassle! It makes good sense to review the information that has been entered into EXDOC by the EXDOC user before the export permit is finalised.

All fish prepared for export must be prepared in an export registered establishment that has specific approval from the department to process the product you want to export. If the establishment is already registered to prepare other fish, but not the type you want to export – the establishment can apply to add this product to their approval.

The processing establishment can identify you as the exporter on the packaging as “Packed for” and your contact details – but must put their own registered establishment number on the labels to identify the processor that carried out the final packing for export.

There may be additional requirements you need to be aware of depending on the country you export to.

Some countries will not accept some species of fish, or have additional product requirements.

Sometimes it is about the processing establishment, for example, the establishment itself must be listed with the country that you want to export to. Examples of this are the EU/UK, Vietnam, China, and Taiwan. So you will need to confirm what country approvals the processing establishment needs.

More information on importing country requirements, including certificate and establishment requirements, can be found online in the Manual of Importing Country Requirements (we call it MICOR). As the exporter, it is YOUR responsibility to make sure importing country requirements are being met for the product you are exporting. And don't forget, you will also need to keep copies of all the documents – including declarations and copies of the issued export documents.

Thanks for watching and don't forget to get in touch with us if you have any video suggestions!

I want to be a processor AND the exporter of the fish products that I make!

There is a big difference between a processor and an exporter. If you want to be both a processor and responsible for exporting the product that you make, then keep watching! If you only want to be the exporter of the product, then watch the video above called ‘I just want to be an exporter (not a processor!)’.

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi! My name is Amy and I am one of the department's Seafood Export Facilitators!

In our video ‘So you want to export seafood?’ we talk about the difference between an exporter and a processor. If you want to be both a processor and responsible for exporting the product, then keep watching!

To be a processor of fish and fish products that are eligible for export – you will need to process your fish in an export registered establishment – we talk more about this in our video – “What happens when I apply for registration”? With your registration comes the Establishment Registration Number (usually 4 digits) that identifies your physical premise. This number will appear on the label of the products that you pack for export (even if you are packing them on behalf of another company or exporter).

If you also want to be the exporter of the product you prepare – you will need another number. We call it your ‘Exporter Number’! You need to complete this form to get an exporter number. If you already have an exporter number for other products, such as meat and dairy, you will still need to submit this form to add fish to your existing number.

All export documentation for fish is electronically managed through the departments Electronic Export Documentation System – we call it EXDOC. EXDOC links with Australia’s customs system, and allows you to generate an export permit for your product. An export permit is required for the product to LEAVE Australia. For some countries you will also need a Health Certificate for the product to ENTER that country. If a health certificate is required, EXDOC will automatically issue this with your export permit.

To access EXDOC yourself you would need to purchase software for your computer – but you can also work with a freight forwarder or agent that already has access to the EXDOC system to do this for you (smaller or infrequent exporters do this all the time).

This is where you need your exporter number, whoever is entering the information into EXDOC will need this number to identify you as the exporter on the export documentation.

The EXDOC user will also have to make a declaration in the system on your behalf. They may request copies of documentation as proof. This is a declaration that all of the information you are providing about the product to be exported is true and correct. There are penalties for making false declarations.

This declaration also states that you – the exporter – have a copy of a Declaration of Compliance signed by someone at your registered establishment. This is sometimes referred to as a ‘manufacturers declaration’.

This declaration must be a document you prepare at your processing establishment when you decide on a customer, and how much product you will export to them. It can also be the declaration made on transfer documentation (usually called a transfer certificate). This would be the declaration you need to make if you are transferring the product from your establishment to another establishment to store or load your product before export.

If the product details entered into EXDOC are not correct – it will not issue an export permit or a Health Certificate if one is required. So always double check the product information you provide to the EXDOC user is correct.

Details of what must be entered into EXDOC include:

- Consignee details (this means who you are sending it to)
- Shipping details (this refers to how you are getting your product to its destination)
- The export registration number of the establishment that processed the product
- Dates of when the product was processed
- A correct description of the product by fish name and species
- Accurate details of the gross and net weight of the product
- And for shellfish like oysters – the date harvested, and the harvest area

It is your responsibility as the exporter to ensure that all of the details entered into EXDOC are correct – incorrect information (for example under estimation of product weights) can result in penalties, detained consignments, or a requirement to return the goods to Australia. Save yourself the hassle! It makes good sense to review the information that has been entered into EXDOC by the EXDOC user before the export permit is finalised.

You can still process product for other exporters, and identify them as the exporter on the packaging – but you will need to include the words “Packed for” and their contact details on the label. You are still required to include your own establishment number on the labels identifying your premise as the place where the product was prepared for export.

There may be additional requirements you need to be aware of depending on the country you export to.

- Some countries will not accept some species of fish, or have additional product requirements that you will need to consider when processing the product.
- Sometimes it is about the processing establishment itself. Some importing countries require the processor to be listed with the country to be able to export there. Examples of this are the EU/UK, Vietnam, China, and Taiwan.

More information on importing country requirements, including certificate and establishment requirements, can be found online in the Manual of Importing Country Requirements (we call it MICOR). As the processor and the exporter, it is YOUR responsibility to make sure importing country requirements are being met for the product you are exporting. And don't forget, you will also need to keep copies of all the documents – including declarations and copies of the issued export documents.

Thanks for watching and don't forget to get in touch with us if you have any video suggestions!

What happens when I apply for registration of an establishment?

Need to know what happens when you apply for registration of an establishment for storing or processing export product? There are three key parts of the process that you need to be aware of: 1) meeting state and council requirements if any, 2) documenting how you will operate your export business, and 3) making your application to the department. Click below for some more detail!

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi my name is Enzina and I am one of the department's Seafood Export Facilitators! In this video I will cover what happens when you apply for registration, and to do this I will step you through three key parts of the process: meeting state and council requirements if any, documenting how you will operate your export business, and last but not least making your application to the department.

In our video 'When is a fish a fish' we talk about the differences between prescribed fish products and fish products that are not prescribed, as well as which products need to be manufactured in an export registered establishment. If you have watched that video and you have now decided that you want to register your establishment for the purposes of preparing or storing product for export, then this is the video for you!

Firstly, you need to ensure that you have met state and council requirements for your business. Requirements will be different from state to state, and may depend on the kind of business you wish to register. For example, requirements for businesses that only store chilled or frozen product as a service may be different to the requirements for manufactures that package the actual product to be exported.

You may also require specific licenses to receive fish directly from fishers or fish farms. So check your business requirements with your state government, local council, and if required the state fisheries authority.

The department registers several types of fish establishments, so you will need to decide which kind you are going to apply for. Different annual registration fees will apply! You can find out more about fees and charges in our charging guidelines.

Types of establishments include:

- Establishments that only store products that will be exported and don't conduct any processing or repackaging for export,
- Establishments that only pack live fish, oysters, and other sea creatures that are exported alive, and
- Establishments that pack and further process fish and fish products (this can include live products).

If you haven't set up your business yet, you will require a suitable premise where you can operate your business. There are not many differences between the structural requirements for a building for processing or storing for export, and a building for supplying food to the domestic market. Export legislation will not tell you exactly how to build your building, but it will tell you the outcomes you need to achieve. For example, the legislation won't tell you what material you need to build your walls, but will specify that whatever material you choose must be smooth, waterproof, and easily cleaned. It is worth noting that there are one or two specific requirements such as non-hand operated taps for hand washing, so check out chapter 4 of the Export Control (Fish and fish product) Rules 2021 for more information – we call them 'The Fish Rules'.

Secondly, you need to document how you will operate your business to ensure that you meet all of the requirements of the export legislation. Chapter 5 of the Fish Rules details what needs to be included in your 'Approved Arrangement.'

An Approved Arrangement, also known as an AA, is the department's name for a food safety management plan. Your AA will need to include requirements similar to state-required food safety plans, plans that you must have in place to supply supermarkets, or for third-party HACCP certification. You may be able to include additional export requirements into your existing plan, and that way you don't need to write a separate document for us. For example, you may have already documented the procedures required to be in an AA, including product specifications, a HACCP plan, associated work instructions, and procedures that cover cleaning, staff training, and pest control.

In case you weren't sure, HACCP stands for Hazard Analysis Critical Control Point, which focuses on the activities you undertake specific to your product.

To meet export requirements, your AA will also need to include:

- A declaration stating your commitment to meet the requirements of the legislation
- A list of the fish products you will be preparing for the export market, AND a list of any non-export products that you process or store. You will need to have procedures in place to identify both kinds of products separately.
- Details of any special requirements you will need to meet if required by the countries you are intending to export to, and
- Details of how you will manage your export documentation, including how you will get export permits, and the documents you will complete when moving product between different export establishments.

Depending on the documented systems that you already have in place it may take time to develop this documentation and the associated record keeping requirements, so it is a good idea to start thinking about what you need to write or add.

Thirdly, here is how to make your application to the department for registration.

You need to:

- Complete an EX26a form that details the location of the premises to be registered.
- Provide information for each person that will be managing or controlling export operations, and finally
- sign and submit the completed form
- Don't worry - there are instructions within the form that will guide you on what you need to do and where you need to send it!

When we receive your application we will look over it to make sure it is correct, and begin a number of different checks. These include:

- A fit and proper person check of all of the people listed on the form to make sure that the person or the company is trustworthy and has no debt owing to a commonwealth institution.
- A check to see if there is any outstanding debt to the department specifically, and
- A departmental auditor will be assigned to your application to do a technical assessment to make sure that your premises meets requirements (this will be a in person site audit), and they will also request a copy of your AA for a desk audit.

The department has 120 days to check your application, this 120 days does not include where the department requests any additional information about your application. This could include requests to clarify information that has already been provided in your AA, or about the structure of your premise. The maximum extension the department can offer at any one time is 6 months. Fees and charges apply for the technical assessment, so the more prepared you are the less time your application should take.

If you engage a consultant to assist you with your AA, ask them about their experience with this kind of documentation, previous references you can speak to about the service they provided, and make sure they are willing to visit your premises and spend some time with you discussing what you want your business to do.

Thanks for your time, make sure you keep an eye out for more videos because we will be covering some of the topics in this video in more detail in the future!

AA series - What is an Approved Arrangement and what does it need to document?

In this video we are going to talk about what you will need to document in your Approved Arrangement (AA), or what you might need to add to your existing food safety plan. We will also touch on the difference between domestic and export requirements in relation to your AA.

Check out our AA checklist to help you work out what you might already have in place, and what you may need to change or add to document your AA.

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi my name is Amy and I am one of the department's Seafood Export Facilitators! In our previous video called 'What happens when I apply for registration?', one of the topics we touched on was the requirements for you to document and submit an approved arrangement – or an 'AA' as we call it. Just to refresh your memory, an AA is the department's name for a food safety management plan. In this video we are going to talk about what you will need to document in YOUR AA, or what you might need to add to your existing food safety plan.

There are some differences between food safety requirements that you must have in place to supply the domestic market, and the requirements you will need to meet to prepare food for export. DOMESTIC

requirements will require you to make sure that you conduct certain activities and keep certain records, for example:

- Keeping your premise clean,
- Keeping records of the temperatures that you store your product at, and
- Keeping records of who you receive products from, and sell products to, so they can be recalled if required.

To meet EXPORT requirements, we will need you to document HOW you will conduct these activities. From here on in, I am going to refer to this detailed and documented food safety plan as an Approved Arrangement, and as I mentioned before we call that an AA. So, AAs are similar to the requirements you need to meet if you are: preparing a high-risk food domestically, supplying a major supermarket chain, or have third party accreditation of your food safety plan.

So just to be clear – the biggest difference between domestic and export food safety plans is that for the majority of lower risk domestic food activities, you are required to conduct your business in a certain way, and keep records of specific things. BUT for all EXPORT activities we are asking you to document HOW and WHEN you will do these things, WHO will do them, and HOW you will check that they are being done as documented.

There is a fairly standard recipe for ensuring food safety. Elements of this usually include:

- ONE - Details of how you will keep your premise and facility clean, well maintained, and free of pests.
- TWO - Procedures for managing your AA, for example details of people's roles and responsibilities, how your staff will be trained, and how you will manage your record keeping.
- THREE – Create documented work instruction for your staff, this will include details of the activities that you undertake at the establishment. How you document this will depend on what you do at your establishment, for example, you will need different instructions for your staff if you are storing frozen food, versus manufacturing a product.
- And FOUR – These work instructions will need to match with the risks that need to be controlled in your business. You will need to work out the risks associated with your business by conducting a hazard analysis.
 - Documenting this part of your AA is referred to as a Hazard Analysis Critical Control Point (or HACCP) plan, which focuses on the activities you undertake specific to your product, or the product that you store.

In this next part of the video, we will talk about documenting requirements for maintaining and operating your facility, how you will monitor this, and the records you will keep.

Your AA will contain details of how you will maintain your facility, and how you will keep it clean and free of pests. It may also include instructions on how you check and record the temperatures of your freezers or cold rooms. These procedures are required to make sure that your premise and activities will prevent the food you prepare from being contaminated by the environment (this could include anything from dust from the driveway, to birds nests, to flaking paint). People can also contaminate product by

handling it incorrectly, not washing their hands before touching exposed food, or being sick when they come into work.

These activities and actions that you take to make sure your product is not contaminated can be referred to as good hygiene practices (GHPs), good management practices (GMPs), support programs, or something similar. To be honest, we don't really mind what you call them, but you will need to document the procedures you have in place so it is clear to us and your staff what needs to be done, when you are going to do it, who is going to do it, how you are going to make sure it gets done, and what evidence you will be able to provide to prove that you have done it. So always remember, when writing about what you do, that you consider the WHO, WHAT, WHEN, WHERE, WHY, and HOW.

By documenting everything about these activities it makes sure that they are carried out the same way every time, and that means that they are under control – and that's important! These procedures also provide instructions to your staff and must be part of their staff training. The kinds of activities that you will need to document should include:

- Staff hygiene procedures and details of their training.
- Cleaning procedures for the building and the equipment in it.
- Maintenance requirements to keep the building and equipment in good working order.
- Calibration and the checks needed to make sure that measurement equipment remains accurate, for example refrigeration gauges, temperature probes, scales, or testing equipment.
- Temperature control, including how you will check your ovens, cookers, freezers, cold rooms, and storage areas. You will need to keep records to show that they are operating at the correct temperature.
- Pest control (don't forget that this includes the areas surrounding the building!), and
- Use of fresh water, salt water, and ice, including how you use it, what it is used for, where it comes from, and how you make sure it is safe for use with food and for cleaning food areas.

Chances are that if you are already operating a successful food business and producing safe food – then you are already doing all of these things – we just need you to write it all down. This may also help you find ways that you can save time and money by having a good look at what it is that you actually do!

Remember – when you are audited (more on how to prepare for THAT in another video) – the auditor will be checking that what you have documented is what you do, and that what you do is what you have documented. Your AA doesn't have to be fancy – it just needs to be accurate and able to be understood by you and your staff.

There are a few things that need to be put into the AA to meet export requirements, and these might be new to you if you are not familiar with preparing food for export. Your AA will need to include:

- A declaration stating your commitment to meeting the legislation.
- A document showing the positions different staff hold in the establishment including who reports to who, who is trained as back up if someone is away, and details of what each position is responsible for doing.

- Details of the products that you intend to prepare for export and where you will get the raw materials from to make them. This is important – for product to be export eligible you will need to understand where and how you source your products and raw materials.
- Details of any special requirements you need to meet for countries you are intending to export to (we usually refer to these as ‘importing country requirements’), and
- Details of how you will manage your export documentation, including who will sign the documents you will complete when moving product between different export establishments.

Your AA will also need to tell us how you are going to keep your documents current, and how you will make sure that the whole system you have documented works. That is, that the AA accurately describes what you do, and what you do meets export requirements. For more information on documenting how you will manage your AA, please watch our next video called ‘Documenting how you will manage your Approved Arrangement’.

Depending on the documents that you may already have, it will take time to develop and document your AA and your record keeping requirements, so it is a good idea to start thinking about what you need to write or add.

Believe me, we know that AAs can seem complex. From here what I would recommend you do is sit down and watch this video again, pause it, take some notes, and have a think about what does and does not make sense for you. Next, I would jump online and have a look at the checklist we have provided for you to help you prepare your AA, and check what you may already have documented. If you are unsure of how a particular requirement needs to be documented, you can also get in contact with one of the Seafood Export Facilitators. We can’t write your AA for you, but we are certainly here to help!

Thanks for listening, and don’t forget to drop us a line if there are any other videos that you would find helpful!

AA series - Documenting how you will manage your Approved Arrangement

In the previous video ‘What is an Approved Arrangement and what does it need to document?’, we talked about documenting your procedures, keeping records, and training your staff. In this video we are talking about the next step in this process which is how you will make sure that all of this actually happens!

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi my name is Amy and I am one of the department’s Seafood Export Facilitators! In our previous video called ‘What is an Approved Arrangement and what does it need to document?’, one of the topics we touched on was documenting how you will manage your AA to make sure it remains current, continues to reflect what you are actually doing, and that the risks you have identified are still being controlled. In this video we are going to talk about the self-checks you will need to carry out and what you will do if you find a problem.

So there may be a few more things that you need to add into your AA to meet these requirements, and these might be new to you if you are not familiar with:

- reviewing your own documented AA,
- documenting what you did if you fixed a problem,
- or keeping records of changes you make to your documents or the way you do things.

In the previous video, we talked about documenting your procedures, keeping records, and training your staff. In this video we are talking about the next step in this process which is how you will make sure that all of this actually happens. To document this process, your AA will need to include procedures for:

- ONE – Making changes to the AA: How you will make and record any changes to your AA, including who is responsible for making and approving these changes. Export legislation allows you to make changes to your AA but you will need to write down the changes you have made as soon as possible after you have made them. These changes are usually recorded in an “Amendments Register” which is just another way of saying a list of changes. This list needs to include details of what changed, when it changed, and who said it was ok to change it. It is important to document the changes that you make – even small changes to what you do can have a negative effect on your business if you don’t have a system of consideration and approval. For example, a change to an ingredient because your usual supplier is out of stock can affect the product you are making if it is not checked out and approved for use by someone that understands the product.
- TWO – Reviewing records: This is the WHO, HOW, and WHEN of how you will double check that everything is being done as documented. This activity is usually part of an internal audit or review of what you do. I say “double check” here because you probably have someone who is already responsible for making checks and keeping records. For example – someone checking and documenting that the processing area is clean before you start handling product, or checking the operating temperatures of your cold rooms and freezers twice every day. BUT – do you ever look at these records to make sure that the person completing them is doing the checks and keeping the records the way that the AA states that they should? This is called a review of monitoring records – and is something that you may want to do at the end of every day or week or season – the timing is up to you – but consider – do you really want to find out that your refrigeration has not been working correctly for 6 months because the person making daily checks did not understand the importance of the checks, or was unclear what to do if there was a problem? It is important that the person reviewing monitoring records is not the same person who conducts the actual activity and keeps the daily records – you want to make sure that the job is being done properly!
- THREE – internal audits: Reviewing monitoring records are completed correctly is just one way of checking your system is working. Other ways are to take a documented procedure in the AA – say the cleaning procedure – and check the whole activity is being carried out as per the document – including checking the who, when, where, why and what is being recorded by observing the actual activity, checking where chemicals are stored, and so on.

It can be a bit of a job – so it pays to break it down into smaller parts and plan for what you will check and when and how you will document what you find, this needs to include what you did about it if you find something that doesn't match up with the AA. Sometimes what you need to do about it can be as simple as updating a procedure in the AA because you have started doing the procedure differently and what you are doing now makes good sense. Depending on the problem this could mean that instead you have to make a plan for equipment to be fixed, or staff to be re-trained in the procedure. This is called taking corrective action, and spoiler alert we love it when you do this BEFORE we turn up for an audit!

- **FOUR – CORRECTIVE ACTION** You will also need to consider and have a plan for what you will do if any of the regular checks you make and record indicate that there is a problem. When you are documenting your AA – you should consider what could go wrong if say for example – your freezer gauge is not reading as cold as you have said it should be. You will need to take some kind of action to correct the situation – because if you don't – your product might end up being damaged or become unsafe.

Taking corrective action is not as simple as just fixing something – again – you need to investigate a bit and figure out why the problem occurred so it doesn't happen again. Sometimes what caused the problem is not always what you first think it might be – for example with the freezer temperatures – the record is showing the freezer is running warm – the first and most important thing to do is check the product and follow the plan in your AA to make sure it stays at the right temperature.

THEN you need to consider why the temperatures are being recorded as warmer than you would like. Does the person making the record understand what they are supposed to be recording? Are staff leaving the door open for extended periods of time for some reason? Is the refrigeration unit breaking down? or was a service call missed? Understanding the cause of the problem means that you can take the action required to prevent it happening again. This is often called a “root-cause analysis” – but it's just a process of writing down what you investigated, and did when something happened, that should not have.

- **FIVE- Keeping everything up to date:** You will need to make sure that your AA is always up to date. To do this you will need to document WHO, HOW, and WHEN the AA will be checked to help make sure it accurately reflects what you do – this is not about checking the records that you make daily – this is about sitting down and reading through your whole AA and checking that you are still doing what you should be doing – this is also part of an internal audit and can be recorded on a checklist so you don't forget anything. The internal audit can be broken up into different parts by subject – for example – one month you might only look at your position descriptions and think about if roles have changed or if you have any new staff, and in the next month you might check that your HACCP plan is still accurate. You will also need to check if there have been any external changes that might affect the accuracy of your AA. This can include if there have been changes to the export legislation, or the requirements of any standards or specifications you refer to in your AA. Examples of this are changes to the Australian fish names standard, or the Australia New Zealand Food Standards Code requirements for your product. If you want to keep up to date you can jump on their websites and subscribe to get their updates.

- **SIX** – Now you need to bring it all together: You will need to document how and when you will have a Management Review Meeting. The meeting will need to be held at least annually, it is important to document who needs to be at the meeting and what you will discuss to make sure that the establishment will continue to meet its export requirements. The results of your internal and external audits can help with this. It is important to record what was decided at the Management Review Meeting, this includes making sure that all corrective actions were followed through and effective in making sure that problems identified in audits or at any other time did not reoccur. If any corrective actions have not been fully completed, this should be written down as well, and then followed up on as soon as possible.

So now you have a documented system! It does need to be kept up to date, but like anything, if you look after it, it will look after you! If you forget anything or are unsure what you need to do, just refer to your AA! If you look after your AA this means you can finally go that holiday because you know your staff have the plan and can refer to it if they need to.

Thanks for listening, we are always open to feedback so we can improve the information that we provide you, so please get in touch!

AA series – Why is HACCP an important part of my AA?

HACCP stands for Hazard Analysis Critical Control Point, and in this video we talk about why you need to have a HACCP plan in your Approved Arrangement (AA), why it is important, what documents it should include, and what you need to do to maintain it.

Video uploaded: 20 June 2023

Hi my name is Amy and I am one of the department's Seafood Export Facilitators! In this video I will cover why you need to have a HACCP plan in your Approved Arrangement, why it is important, what documents it should include, and what you need to do to maintain it. In case you weren't sure, HACCP stands for Hazard Analysis Critical Control Point and it focuses on the activities you undertake specific to your product.

You need to include a HACCP plan in your AA because it is the key for safe food production, and it is what the Export legislation requires. In the previous video in this series called 'What is an Approved Arrangement and what does it need to document?', you will remember that we talked about documenting the activities that you undertake at your establishment to prevent your product being cross contaminated. These controls are the ones that need to be in place no matter what kind of export products are being prepared, or for that matter, what kind of food is being prepared. Think of it as being the same as what you would do at home. For example, washing your hands after you have been to the bathroom, or before you start preparing food, and not storing cleaning chemicals in the fridge! HACCP is where we get specific. You now have the general controls in place, HACCP is about having a closer look at the product you are preparing or storing for export.

HACCP has been around for a long time. our export rules, recommend that you look at the CODEX requirements for HACCP plans. CODEX has been around since the 1960s and refers to food safety

standards that have been agreed to on an international level, and this includes general agreement to using HACCP as a tool for managing food safety worldwide. There is a lot of information available online about developing HACCP plans, including where you can attend training courses to help you understand HACCP and how it effects your business. We aren't going to duplicate what is already out there, and this isn't a training course. Instead, what we will do in this video is cover the minimum requirements for a HACCP plan that needs to be included in your AA. Even if you are going to get external help with this part of your documentation, or if you have trained Quality Assurance staff working for you, it will be helpful for YOU to understand how it works.

HACCP describes a process used to have a very close look at the product you are making for export, this includes considering all of the things that could possibly go wrong while you are making the product, or even just storing it. As you can see already, depending on what you are making or just storing, this process can be complicated or it can be simple. Either way, unless you are a sole operator, you will need a team to get this done. This is not because it is a huge task, it is because you need information from all parts of your business to do it properly. You may find that you require external assistance to document or develop your HACCP plan, this assistance may be in anything from simply typing up the document, through to seeking help from someone trained in developing HACCP plans. All of that is fine! BUT REMEMBER, they will only be ONE member of your whole HACCP team!

So, remembering that today we are only going to touch on the minimum requirements you need in your HACCP plan, we will now break down the documents that you need to provide to us.

- ONE – A fully documented product specification for the product or products that you are making or storing. If you are just storing frozen seafood that has been prepared by someone else, you would probably be tempted to DESCRIBE the product as 'frozen seafood'. However, we do need you to think a little bit more about it, is your 'frozen seafood' a product that needs to be held at a specific temperature? Or handled in a particular way? Is this something that you need to add to your description so that it is clear? For example, is the product you are actually storing better described as 'Pre-packaged frozen seafood, to be stored at colder than -18oC'. Adding this additional detail turns your product DESCRIPTION into a product SPECIFICATION. So now you have documented not only what you are storing, but also the conditions it needs to be stored under. You can now demonstrate and document (prove!) that you are complying with your product specification by taking the temperature of the product with a probe or by referencing the refrigeration gauge.

Obviously, product specifications for the products that you are MAKING are going to be more detailed because there are more things to consider. For example

- What does my customer want?
- What size boxes am I going to put it in?
- What temperature does it need to be stored at?
- Are there any legal requirements that the product has to meet? This could include considering things like the kind of ingredients you are allowed to use under the food standards code, through to meeting requirements for export labelling.

Consider that you may need more than one product specification if you are making more than one type of product. A detailed product specification will mean you have something you can measure your

product against when you have finished making it. You can now PROVE that you have made exactly what you set out to make.

- TWO – A description of all of the steps in the process for making or storing your product. If you are only storing frozen product, this can be as simple as:

Step 1) receive frozen product into the establishment,

Step 2) store in the freezer at below -300C,

Step 3) select stock,

Step 4) load refrigerated transport.

OR, if you are processing your product it can be complex. For example, the steps that would be included in a process where frozen abalone is received and processed for export into cans. Simple or complex, it is important to get the steps right. We are happy for these steps to be presented in a diagram, HACCP calls this a 'flow diagram'. So I think that a diagram is a good place for your HACCP team to start. To make sure that you have included all of the steps, it helps to walk through the actual process while it is happening, or if it is a new process, involving your HACCP team to test the diagram together. They will think of things that you don't, or even steps that you have missed!

The other important consideration is to think about when a step is a step. To keep this process simple and accurate, think about the product and what happens to it at each step in your process. A common mistake is to combine too many activities into one step. For example, 'packing and weighing' may be an accurate description of the step if one person is packing product into a box on a scale and weighing it at the same time. But, this is not an accurate description if one person packs the product into the box on one side of the factory, and another person weighs the product in a different area or on a different day. The important thing to focus on is what is happening to the product at each step of the process. Is it just sitting in the freezer waiting to be processed at the next step? Are you doing something to the product during this step such as cooking it or freezing it? Each step is about the product and what is happening to it during that step. It is NOT about cleaning the factory before you start processing, or training your staff in how to operate the cooker. It is too late to do these things, because right now you are in the middle of processing!!

- THREE – Documenting the hazard analysis. This may be the part where you may need external help. In summary, this is where you consider each step individually in more detail and document what could possibly go wrong, and what you are going to do about it. In HACCP language you are now 'conducting a hazard analysis'. This might seem like a huge task, I mean for example the roof could cave in!! ANYTHING could happen!! It isn't actually about ANYTHING that could possibly go wrong. It is about what would be "reasonably expected to occur". This is where your knowledge of your product and your business comes into play. You have already documented in your Approved Arrangement how you will control the obvious things like cross contamination of the product by pests, people, or poor cleaning. AND you know that the roof isn't going to cave in because you have control of this through your maintenance program. Other things you already have under control should include: the approval of suppliers of your raw material, the operation of your refrigeration system, and your staff training. To remind you of what you already have under control you might want to have another look at our video called 'What is an Approved Arrangement and what does it need to document?'.

So, now your HACCP team can focus on each step in your flow diagram, using your knowledge of the product and the process to document what you do. There are several commonly used formats for this, we don't mind what format you use, as long as your document clearly shows that you have considered what can go wrong at each step. By 'wrong' we mean go wrong in such a way that the product you are preparing could cause physical, chemical, or biological harm to the end consumer. To complete this analysis correctly it is important to think about what could CAUSE things to go wrong, and detail the controls that you have, or will put in place to PREVENT this from happening. If you are already operating a successful business and produce a good product (or intend to!), chances are you already have the required controls in place. It's just that you may not have looked at the things you do as 'controls' before, or documented them in this way.

Conducting and documenting a hazard analysis will allow you to work out if there are any steps in your process that are critical for making sure that the product you produce is safe. These are called Critical Control Points, or CCPs for short. These typically include steps in a process where you may be actively trying to destroy harmful bacteria by cooking or canning the product. This can include the step where you receive the product, as this may be the only step in the process where you can prevent unsafe product entering your premises. For example, you don't want to receive fish that contains toxins that cooking or even canning will not destroy. It is safe to say that not having the right CCPs can be bad for business!

If your hazard analysis indicates that there are no critical steps in your process, and that you can produce a safe product under your more general controls, then this is where you can celebrate because you can skip the documents required in step 4!

- **FOUR – Documenting the HACCP table.** If critical control points are identified, you will need to document these in a new table usually called a 'HACCP table'. Again, there are lots of different formats that you can use for this. BUT, at a minimum your HACCP table needs to include each step in your process that includes a CCP. You will need to detail how you monitor each CCP to make sure it is always under control, including what ACTION you will take if something goes wrong. The HACCP plan also needs to include details of who is responsible for monitoring, how and when they will monitor, and where they will document the results of their monitoring. Make sure when you read through your hazard analysis and HACCP plan that this all makes sense to YOU! This is your product, your process, your people, and you know it best! If it doesn't describe what you do, the document is not going to help you to ensure your food is safe!

It is important that you and all of your staff understand what their role is, why it is important, and what they need to do if something unexpected happens. You do this by having documented work instructions, and by training staff in processes that have been identified as critical. This includes: training in monitoring, record keeping, and confirmation that they understand the action to take if something goes wrong at a step in the process. You will also need documented procedures showing how your HACCP plan is going to be maintained, and how you will PROVE it works. That is, if you follow your HACCP plan the product that you prepare continues to be safe to eat and is able to be exported. We will talk about maintaining your AA (including the HACCP plan!) and checking that your whole system of controls works in our next video called 'Maintaining your Approved Arrangement and documenting corrective action'.

Hopefully this video has helped you to understand a bit more about what we require to be in your HACCP plan. You should think about HACCP plans as your “working out” documents. It’s the process behind what you are going to make, how you are going to make it, and documents that you have taken due care in making sure that the product is safe to eat. This means that it is VERY important to make sure that all of the details in your HACCP plan, including product specifications and flow diagrams, are up to date and accurately reflect what you are doing NOW. Your whole HACCP plan must be reviewed at least annually even if you have been doing the same thing for years! AND you need to document this process! I can’t stress this enough, it is incredibly important that you revisit your HACCP plan prior to making any changes to your products or processes because a small change, when analysed properly, could turn out to be critical!

Thanks for watching and make sure to check out the rest of our videos!

AA series – Maintaining your Approved Arrangement and documenting corrective action

Your AA is a manual that explains everything you do at your establishment. In this video we go into detail about keeping it up to date and provide examples to show why it is important to do this! We also talk about the big picture behind why we (your establishment and the department together) do all of this in the first place.

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Hi my name is Amy and I am one of the department’s Seafood Export Facilitators! Hopefully by now you have watched all of the other videos in this series on Approved Arrangements. If you are new to exporting product or are developing your Approved Arrangement, I would recommend going back into the video resources library and starting from the top! We have been building on the information in each video, so you will need to watch those to get the whole picture! If you already have an Approved Arrangement in place, you are starting in a new role in the establishment, or you think this video might help your staff in understanding how to work under an Approved Arrangement then lets get started!

Just to refresh your memory, we call an Approved Arrangement an ‘AA’, and an AA is the department's name for a food safety management plan. In the AA series so far, we have talked a lot about what needs to be documented, and the importance of the documentation matching up with what you make and do at YOUR establishment. We have also talked about the additional checks, for example internal audits, that you will make to ensure that your system is working. We have also talked about planning ahead in your HACCP plan and considering the corrective action you will need to take if something goes wrong. In this video we are going to talk about how you make sure that your AA documentation remains up to date and continues to match with what you do, even if you change the product that you are processing, how you process it, or if you have made changes because something has gone wrong.

At this stage you have a documented system in place. Think of your AA as a manual that explains everything you do at your establishment, including who is responsible for doing it, when they need to do it, and what forms they need to fill out so you can prove that it has been done. Documenting the WHO,

WHEN and HOW shows that you have control of your operations, including how the system is regularly checked – this means that the same thing is going to get done the same way every time unless you decide to change it.

But what about the WHY? Now is probably a good time to refocus on why you are doing all of this. The first page of your AA will contain some kind of statement, declaration, or commitment that has been made by the person with the highest level of responsibility at your establishment. This declaration includes a commitment to meeting the objectives of the export legislation, including a commitment to preparing food for export that is:

- Safe and fit for purpose,
- Meets importing country requirements,
- Is accurately identified and labelled, and
- Is traceable and can be recalled if needed.

The AA that you have documented demonstrates that you now have a system in place at your establishment that will make sure these objectives are met. This is how these two ideas of the AA and the declaration are connected.

All export registered establishments need to make this declaration because it is important not only to YOUR establishment, and YOUR customers, it is important to ALL export registered establishments. This system of documented controls is how the Australian government provides assurances to importing countries, that ALL exported Australian seafood meets Australian standards. These are the same food safety standards that Australia applies to the food that you eat at home. ALSO, when a country has different food safety standards to Australia, we can demonstrate that we have a system of controls in place to make sure that these can also be met.

It is important for you to understand that an issue with seafood from ANY establishment, can impact ALL seafood establishments and your access to those overseas markets.

So now that you understand the big picture, lets get into the detail and talk about how you are going to manage CHANGES to your AA and how you will keep it up to date. Things change all the time, the department understands this and we are a part of this process too!

- These may be changes you WANT to make, like exporting to a new destination, or producing an exciting new product.
- There can also be changes you NEED to make to keep your AA up to date, for example, when there are changes to the legislation.
- AND changes you MUST make to your AA when something goes wrong. Nothing stays the same forever!

SO, there are changes that you WANT to make, changes that you NEED to make, and there are some changes that you have to let us know about BEFORE you make them. You will already be aware of some of the changes that you need to let us know about, this includes: applying to the department for registration of your establishment BEFORE you start exporting! Most of the changes that you need to advise the department of are part of our daily business. For example, when your business changes

hands, processing your applications to make changes to persons in control of your establishment, approving new product lines or processes when you submit an application for variation, or requesting a new fish cut code.

You may WANT to make changes to your business, like exploring new markets. When you find a new market or a new customer there are likely to be new requirements related to accessing the market itself, or meeting your customers specific needs. Checking your AA will help you understand if you are already prepared for this change, or if there is something else you need to do or consider.

Regardless of the kind of change being made, you will need to consider if this effects your AA. The way that your business manages day to day changes should already be detailed in your AA. For example, instructions for how you manage new suppliers, or instructions for what you need to think about and document if you are sourcing new cleaning chemicals. Outside of these day-to-day changes, anything else you change is likely to affect your documented AA. It is important that you record ANY changes that you make to your AA documentation, this includes: changes around the forms that you use to record information, through to changes that you make to how you train your staff. Remember, your AA needs to reflect what you are doing NOW, and as a result you need to record any changes in writing as soon as possible after you have made them. This is typically recorded in an amendments register. Your amendments register is going to be one of the first documents that will be requested when a departmental staff member audits your establishment. By looking at the amendments register the auditor can quickly see where and when a change has been made. This will make it clear to the auditor that any changes found at audit, for example a change in how you keep your temperature records, was done in a controlled way. REMEMBER, if you don't write it down, it's hard to prove that it happened!

You will need to make time for the changes you NEED to make. Keeping your AA up to date can take time! Your AA may include references to other documents, legislation, or standards that are also regularly updated. Remember to make time for these cross-checks. Planning to make regular checks of your AA documentation and your system is required to make sure that you continue to meet your legislative requirements – these internal checks are typically referred to as “Internal Audits”. Establishments with more than two staff members are also required to hold annual Management Review Meetings where the results of these internal audits are considered and documented.

Now for the changes to your AA that you MUST make when something goes wrong. If your system is working as it is set up to, you will know when something is not working as it should.

You have already set up your checks and balances. Your first indication that something is not working as it should is when there is evidence from your monitoring records that something is not to specification. For example, the daily check of your refrigeration shows the gauge is reading -15 degrees when your specification at this check is -30 degrees.

If your system is working as it should – your staff will know what to do now because you have trained them and documented the action they should take in your AA. And remember why we are doing all of this – the first action that needs to be taken is ALWAYS going to be about the product you are making and keeping it safe.

We don't care if you find a problem, that is exactly what your system is supposed to do! This is usually fairly straightforward – you find the cause of the problem and fix it, but you may not think to record your actions – or realise that you may need to make changes to your AA.

You may also not think of what you do next as “taking effective corrective action”.

In this example, what is important is that you:

- Take action to make sure the product is still at the required temperature and take steps to keep it this way.
- Work out what could have caused the problem: It could be that staff are leaving the freezer door open for long periods of time, your refrigeration system needs a maintenance check, or the staff are checking the gauges when the refrigeration is on it's defrost cycle.
- With a bit of investigation and a check of previous monitoring records – you find that the staff member that is checking the gauges and recording the temperatures is doing this at random times of the day and the high temperature was recorded while the freezer was in fact on its normal defrost cycle.
- At this point – you can tell the staff member that you now want the gauges checked and recorded twice daily – once at 7am and again at 3pm – problem fixed!

Not quite.

In our freezer example – you decide you will verbally re-train your staff member – but remember – you have now decided on new daily temperature checks of the freezer and your AA needs to reflect what you actually do. Your current AA states that staff check the freezer temperature daily – you have now changed their instructions to twice daily.

You may also find that a change to one part of the manual may not be enough, and you need to make changes in other parts as well to keep the system working. Consider what is on the freezer temperature recording form – is there space for recording two temperatures a day? Or do you need to add in a section for recording the new times?

The final step in this process is to write down:

- what the problem was
- what you did in the short term to correct it (including what was done with any product that might have been affected)
- what you found caused the problem and what longer term action you took to prevent the problem happening again – including any changes you needed to make to your AA system and record it in the amendments register
- and how you will check that your change was effective during your next internal audit.

This “corrective action” procedure is a necessary part of keeping your AA system working and identifies areas where you can improve the way you do business by identifying small issues before they turn into bigger ones. It is also the same procedure you will use when you are not the one identifying the problems – it may be your customer who has a complaint, it may be an auditor that identifies an issue –

either way – the important thing is that you have a system in place to effectively manage any issues identified so that you can keep your business on track!

Thanks for listening and happy exporting!

Other resources

Seafood Export Facilitator service

The department offers a free Seafood Exporter Facilitator (SEF) service. The SEF provides one-on-one support to existing export registered establishments as well as potential exporters that are seeking to become export registered. To find out how to contact the SEF check out our [Seafood Export Facilitator service](#) webpage.

Video uploaded: 17 January 2023

Hi, my name is Lisa, and I'm one of the seafood export facilitators at the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

I've worked in the seafood industry for most of my career, and I've spent time on fishing vessels in seafood processing establishments, delivering seafood HACCP training and working in the state and commonwealth governments.

As a seafood export facilitator, I can provide advice and support to help you export seafood products overseas.

I can help you with understanding documentation and registration, getting new exporters on the front foot and helping existing exporters to understand new and changing importing country requirements.

Our short videos. step you through a number of frequently asked questions.

If you'd like some support or to suggest video topics, I'm able to help you with this.

Just send me an email and I'll point you in the right direction.

Email address: SeafoodExportSupport@aff.gov.au

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/fish/seafood-video-resources>